

Session 18: Literary Representation and “Reality”

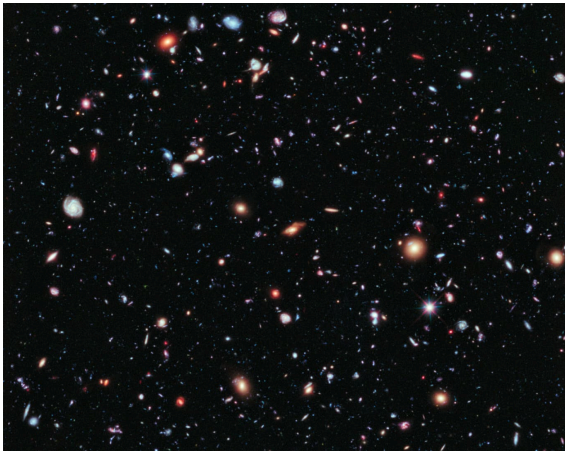
Key Takeaways

- When we read biblical narrative, we are reading an interpretation of the biblical events within the stylized poetics (i.e., conventions) of biblical narrative.
- Biblical narrative invites us into the narrative world of the authors, and it also invites us to view the world from their perspective. The narratives work on you, and over time, they begin to affect the way we view ourselves and the world we’re living in.
- When reading the Hebrew Bible, it is helpful to familiarize ourselves with the basic elements of ancient Near Eastern culture to gain insight into the culture of the ancient Israelites.
- However, the main key to understanding the text is the text itself. For example, to understand one narrative in Genesis, we need to understand it in light of the entire Genesis scroll and the TaNaK as a whole.

The Poetics of Biblical Narrative

Biblical narrative is a highly stylized kind of literature that (1) recounts Israel’s history while (2) at the same time offering a prophetic interpretation of that history.

- Discerning the historical truthfulness of the biblical story is an important topic of research and debate, but it should not be confused with interpretation of these carefully crafted narratives. In other words, apologetics should not be confused with interpretation.
- Biblical narrative does not offer us security-camera footage of ancient Israelite history. Rather, the authors have employed the historiographical tools of “selectivity” and “thematic arrangement” to construct narratives with stylized conventions of plot, characterization, setting, and design patterns. Their rhetorical goal is to help the reader see the meaning and significance of the story they are telling.



Left: Hubble Telescope (2009). *Hubble Deep Field Image*. ([Wikimedia Commons](#)). Right: van Gogh, Vincent (1889). *The Starry Night*. ([Wikimedia Commons](#)).

To illustrate this point, consider these two images of stars in the sky. Which image presents the night sky as it actually is?

Neither one, of course! Both images are representations of the starry universe portrayed through different media, for different purposes, and with different effects on the viewer.

Neither one is the starry universe itself. The Hubble photo represents a maximal realism, while *The Starry Night* employs an impressionistic style. But both are images, or colored pixels on a two-dimensional surface of digital paper. That is a far cry from the actual night sky!

The Starry Night conveys the impression and feeling of the night sky as it is relevant to a small human community. It communicates much through minimal detail, and uses juxtaposition and contrast (swirling skies versus geometric human buildings) as well as similarity (blue tones in the sky and on land).

“A photograph of a tree is a good example of the distinction between a text and the event depicted in it. A photograph is a representation of a tree, yet it does not have bark and leaves, nor is the sky behind the tree a real sky. To say that a photograph only represents the tree but is not actually the tree does not mean the tree never existed or that the photograph is inaccurate because it only shows one side of the tree. The same can be said of the biblical narrative texts. To say they re-present events but are not the events themselves is simply to recognize a very obvious fact about biblical narratives: They are texts, which means we stand not before events, but representations of events through words.”

Sailhamer, John (1999). [Introduction to Old Testament Theology](#). Zondervan Academic. 47.

Text Versus Event and the Meaning of Biblical Narrative

A text provides a literary representation of an object that helps the reader grasp its meaning and significance from a particular perspective.

“The Treachery of Images” by Rene Magritte provides a classic example of the difference between an object and its representation.

“Ah, the famous pipe. How people reproached me for it! And yet, could you stuff my pipe? No, it’s just a representation, is it not? So if I had written on my picture ‘This is a pipe’, I’d have been lying!”

Harry Torczyner, [Magritte: The True Art of Painting](#). 85.



Magritte, René (1929). *The Treachery of Images*. [Wiki Art](#)

In the Bible, the real world is mediated to the reader not only through the narrative text but also via the narrative world that frames the author’s text.



The Mediation of Meaning Through Narrative. Diagram created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

The biblical authors “take the raw material of language and shape it into a version of the world of empirical reality. It’s essentially linguistic structures that are adapted to conform to events in real life ... The reader looks at the events in the narrative in much the same way as he or she would look at events in real life, which makes it easy to forget that one is looking at words not the event itself ... While there are other avenues through which information can be gained about the real world events beyond the text, they are not, in fact, part of the text and not controlled by the author of the text. Whatever may be said about the world behind the narrative, it should not be identified with the narrative world depicted in the text itself. The textual world is a version of the events it depicts. It should not be taken as their replacement.”

What Does This Mean for the Hebrew Bible?

The Hebrew Bible is a literary representation of Israel's history that claims to be a divinely inspired, prophetic interpretation of Israel's history. It is not a history of Israel but a theological interpretation of Israel's story in the context of a cosmic history of creation (Gen. 1-11). The narrative claims to both represent history and to show its meaning and significance, with the aim of eliciting a response from the reader.

When reading the Hebrew Bible, we need to become familiar with the basic elements of ancient Near Eastern culture, but the primary focus of our efforts to understand the text should be the text itself. In other words, the entire TaNaK is the first and most primary context for the meaning of the biblical text.

Recommended Resources

Here is a starter's bibliography on biblical narrative.

- J.P. Fokkelman, [*Reading Biblical Narrative: An Introductory Guide*](#).
- Robert Alter, [*The Art of Biblical Narrative*](#).
- Adele Berlin, [*Interpretation of Biblical Narrative*](#).
- Shimon Bar-Efrat, [*Narrative Art in the Bible*](#).

Reflection Question

Have you ever thought of the biblical text as a representation of reality rather than as the reality itself? What does this mean for what we will encounter in the text? If it is a representation, can it still be truthful?